

Citizen Designer

Perspectives on Design Responsibility

Edited by
Steven Heller and
Véronique Vienne



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Introduction

i Steven Heller

Milton Glaser often says, “Good design is good citizenship.” But does this mean making good design is an indispensable obligation to the society and culture in which designers are citizens? Or does it suggest that design has inherent properties that when applied in a responsible manner contribute to a well-being that enhances everyone’s life as a citizen?

For the answer we must also ask the questions: What is good design? Is it rightness of form or aesthetic perfections: Is it flawless conception or intelligent usability? The converse, bad or poor design, is design that doesn’t work. So, is bad design bad citizenship? In fact, bad design is just plain mean while good design presumably serves many citizens.

Nonetheless, “goodness” is subjective, and one can be a good (or great) designer without necessarily being a good citizen. But if good design (regardless of style or mannerism) adds value to society, by either pushing the cultural envelope or maintaining the status quo at a high level, then design and citizenship must go hand in hand.

Thomas Watson Jr. said, “Good design is good business.” When the former IBM chairman and leading American corporate design patron proclaimed this in the fifties, business was the white knight of postwar American society. Yet during the subsequent years, good business has not always been good business, and good design has sometimes unwittingly supported bad companies. Business malfeasance is all too common these days. For example, having risen to the level of tragic comedy, Enron’s shenanigans were the apotheosis of corporate wrongdoing in the year 2002. During the process of spiraling into the abyss, Enron’s design — specifically the Enron logo created by Paul Rand in 1996 — became the MGM (Money Grabbing Mongrels) lion of greed and corruption. Rand’s mark was created to bond Enron’s workforce to the corporate culture while branding

the company's positive assets on the nation's consciousness. In the modernist tradition, graphic design was employed to foster professionalism, and in this instance Enron's mark helped unify the chaos of its sprawling business. At the time, there was no hint that Enron's leaders would defraud employees or investors, in fact, just the opposite. As a new energy conglomerate, it assured jobs for thousands and services to millions. Good design underscored the promise of good business, and, by extension, good citizenship. But when Enron started to rot from the inside the logo became an icon of decay.

So, what is the responsibility of a designer when design is impeccable, but the client is gained? Being accountable to some moral standard is the key. A designer must be professionally, culturally, and socially responsible for the impact his or her design has on the citizenry. Indeed, every good citizen must understand that his or her design has on the citizenry. Indeed, every good citizen must understand that his or her respective actions will have reactions. All individual acts, including the creation and manufacture of design for a client, exert impact on others. But Rand could not foresee Enron's gross betrayal. And even if large corporations are sometimes suspect, why should he or any designer refuse to work for Enron or any similar establishment? A designer cannot afford to hire investigators to compile dossiers about whether a business is savory or not. Yet certain benchmarks must apply, such as knowing what, in fact, a company does and how it does it. And if a designer has any doubts, plenty of public records exist that provide for informed decisions; however, each designer must address this aspect of good citizenship as he or she sees fit.

Two years ago, when Milton Glaser was illustrating Dante's Purgatory, he became interested in the "Road to Hell" and developed a little questionnaire to see where he stood in terms of his own willingness to lie. Beginning with fairly minor misdemeanors, the following twelve steps increase to some major indiscretions.

1. Designing a package to look bigger on the shelf.
2. Designing an ad for a slow, boring film to make it seem like a light-hearted comedy.
3. Designing a crest for a new vineyard to suggest that it has been in business for a long time.
4. Designing a jacket for a book whose sexual content you find personally repellent.
5. Designing a medal using steel from the World Trade Center to be sold as a profit-making souvenir of September 11.
6. Designing an advertising campaign for a company with a history of known discrimination in minority hiring.

7. Designing a package for children whose contents you know are low in nutrition value and high in sugar content.
8. Designing a line of T-shirts for a manufacturer that employs child labor.
9. Designing a promotion for a diet product that you know doesn't work.
10. Designing an ad for a political candidate whose policies you believe would be harmful to the general public.
11. Designing a brochure for an SUV that turned over frequently in emergency conditions and was known to have killed 150 people.
12. Designing an ad for a product whose frequent use could result in the user's death.

A dozen additional steps of varied consequence should be added, but Glaser's list addresses a significant range of contentious issues. Designers are called upon to make routine decisions regarding scale, color, image, etc. — things that may seem insignificant but will inevitably affect behavior in some way. An elegant logo can legitimize the illegitimate; a beautiful package can spike up the sales of an inferior product; an appealing trade character can convince kids that something dangerous is essential. The graphic designer is as accountable as the marketing and publicity departments for the propagation of a message or idea.

Talented designers are predisposed to create good-looking work. We are taught to marry type and image into pleasing and effective compositions that attract the eye and excite the senses. Do this well, we're told, and good jobs are plentiful; do it poorly and we'll produce junk mail for the rest of our lives. However, to be what in this book we call a "citizen designer" requires more than talent. As Glaser notes, the key is to ask questions, for the answers will result in responsible decisions. Without responsibility, talent is too easily wasted on waste.

This book examines and critiques through essays and interviews three areas in which designers practice and in which responsibility to oneself and society is essential. Sections on Social Responsibility, Professional Responsibility, and Artistic Responsibility offer insight into how our peers view their practices as dependent on moral codes. The final part, Raves and Rants, is a soapbox, pure and simple. Our goal in editing this book is not to offer dogmatic decrees or sanctimonious screeds but to address the concern that the design field, like society as a whole, is built on the foundation of... well, you fill in the blank.

Part One

Social Responsibility

Good Citizenship

Design as a Social and Political Force

👤 Katherine McCoy

This decade finds us in a crisis of values in the United States. Our increasingly multicultural society is experiencing a breakdown in shared values — national values, tribal values, personal values, even family values — consensual motivating values that create a common sense of purpose in a community.

The question is: How can a heterogeneous society develop shared values and yet encourage cultural diversity and personal freedom? Designers and design education are part of the problem and can be part of the answer. We cannot afford to be passive anymore. Designers must be good citizens and participate in the shaping of our government and society. As designers, we could use our particular talents and skills to encourage others to wake up and participate as well.

Before the U.S. congratulates itself too much on the demise of Communism, we must remember that our American capitalist democracy is not what it used to be, either. Much of our stagnation comes from this breakdown of values. Entrepreneurial energy and an optimistic work ethic have deteriorated into individual self-interest, complacency, corporate free, and resentment between ethnic groups and economic classes. Our traditional common American purpose is fading — that sense of building something new where individuals could progress through participating in a system that provided opportunity. Consumerism and materialism now seem to be the only ties that bind. The one group that seems to be bound by more than this is the Far Right; but their bond is regressive, a desire to force fundamentalist prescriptive values on the rest of us.

In the Reagan-Bush era we were told it was all O.K., that we could spend and consume with no price tag attached. During this period, graphic designers enjoyed the spinals of artificial prosperity with the same passive hedonism as the rest of

the country. Now we are beginning to realize it was not all O.K. The earth is being poisoned, its resources depleted, and the U.S. had gone from a creditor to a debtor nation. Our self-absorption and lack of activism has left a void filled by minority single-issue groups aggressively pushing their concerns.

There are serious threats to our civil liberties in the United States from both fundamentalist censorship of the Right and political correctness from the Left. We have seen the dismemberment of artistic freedom at the National Endowment for the Arts in recent years, and aggressive attempts to censor public schools' teaching — from Darwin to Hemingway to safe sex — continue. A conservative Congress continues to push for content restrictions on Internet discourse. And as graphic designers specializing in visual communications, the content of our communications could be seriously curtailed if we do not defend our freedom of expression.

But even more troubling is our field's own self-censorship. How many graphic designers today would feel a loss if their freedom of expression were handcuffed? Most of our colleagues never exercise their right to communicate on public issues or potentially controversial content. Remove our freedom of speech and graphic designers might never notice. We have trained a profession that feels political or social concerns are extraneous to our work, or inappropriate.

Thinking back to 1968, the atmosphere at Unimark International during my first year of work typified this problem. Unimark (an idealistic international design office with Massimo Vignelli and Jay Doblin as vice presidents and Herbert Bayer on the board) was dedicated to the ideal of the rationally objective professional. The graphic design was to be the neutral transmitter of the client's messages. Clarity and objectivity were the goal. During that year, the designers I worked with, save one notable exception, were all remarkably disinterested in the social and political upheavals taking place around us. Vietnam was escalating with body counts touted on every evening newscast; the New Left rioted before the Democratic National Convention in Chicago; Martin Luther King and Robert Kennedy were assassinated; and Detroit was still smoking from its riots just down the street from our office. Yet hardly a word was spoken on these subjects. We were encouraged to wear white lab coats, perhaps so the messy external environment would not contaminate our surgically clean detachment.

These white lab coats make an excellent metaphor for the apolitical designer, cherishing the myth of universal, value-free design, that design is a clinical process akin to chemistry, scientifically pure and neutral, conducted in a sterile laboratory environment with precisely predictable results. Yet Lawrence and Oppenheimer and a thousand other examples teach us that even chemists and physicists must have a contextual view of their work in the socio-political world around them.

During that time, I became increasingly interested in the social idealism of the times: the Civil Rights movement, the anti-Vietnam peace movement, the anti-materialism and social experimentation of the New Left, and radical feminism. Yet

it was very difficult to relate these new ideas to the design that I was practicing and the communication process that I loved so much. Or perhaps the difficulty was not the values of design so much as the values of the design community. About all I could connect with was designing and sending (to appalled family members) an anti-Vietnam, feminist Christmas card and sold screening T-shirts with a geometricized “Swiss” version of the feminist symbol. Meanwhile, we continued to serve the corporate and advertising worlds with highly “professional” design solutions.

The implication of the word “professional” as we use it is indicative of the problem here. How often do we hear, “Act like a professional” or “I’m a professional, I can handle it?” Being a professional means to put aside one’s personal reactions regardless of the situation and to carry on. Prostitutes, practitioners of the so-called oldest profession, must maintain an extreme of cool objectivity about this most intimate of human activities, highly disciplining their personal responses to deliver an impartial and consistent product to their clients.

This ideal of the dispassionate professional distances us from ethical and political values. Think of the words used to describe the disciplined, objective professional, whether it be scientist, doctor, or lawyer: “impartial,” “dispassionate,” “disinterested.” These become pejorative terms in a difficult world crying for compassion, interest, concern, commitment, and involvement. Disinterest is appropriate for a neutral arbitrator but not for an advocate. In fact, design education most often trains students to think of themselves as passive arbitrators of the message between the client/sender and audience/receiver, rather than as advocates for the message content or the audience. Here is the challenge: how to achieve the objectivity and consistency of professionalism without stripping oneself of personal convictions.

Our concept of graphic design professionalism has been largely shaped, and generally for the better, by the legacy of twentieth-century modernism as it has come to us through the Bauhaus and Swiss lineages. However, there are several dominant aspects of this modernist ethic that have done much to distance designers from their cultural milieu. The ideals, forms, methods, and mythology of modernism are a large part of this problem of detachments, including the paradigms of universal form, abstraction, self-referentialism, value-free design, rationality, and objectivity.

Objective rationalism, particularly that of the Bauhaus, provided a much-needed antidote to the sentimentality and gratuitous eclecticism found in nineteenth-century mass production, visual communications, and architecture. Linked to functionalism, objective analysis formed the basis of problem-solving methods to generate functional design solutions to improve the quality of daily life. Expanded more recently to include systems design, this attitude has done much to elevate the quality of design thinking.

Linked to the ideal of the objective, clear-sighted design is the ideal of value-free universal forms. Perhaps a reaction to the frequent political upheavals between European nations, especially World War I, early-modern designers hoped to find internationalist design forms and attitudes that would cross those national, ethnic, and class barriers that had caused such strife. In addition, a universal design — one design for all — would be appropriate for the classless mass society of industrial workers envisioned by early-twentieth-century social reformers.

But passing years and different national contexts have brought different results from the application of these modernist design paradigms. The myth of objectivity unfortunately does much to disengage the designer from compassionate concerns. Strongly held personal convictions would seem to be inappropriate for the professional. Functionalism is narrowly defined in cool-headed, objective, utilitarian terms. Too often this means serving the client’s definition of function — generally profits — over other concerns, including safety, the environment, and social/cultural/political impacts. Universalism has brought us the homogenized proper corporate style based mainly on Helvetica and the grid, ignoring the power and potential of regional, idiosyncratic, personal, or culturally specific stylistic vocabularies. And the ideal of value-free design is a dangerous myth. In fact, all design solutions carry a bias, either explicit or implicit. The more honest designs acknowledge their biases openly rather than manipulate their audiences with assurances of universal “truth” and purity.

Abstraction, modernism’s revolutionary contribution to the visual language of art and design, further distances both designer and audience from involvement. Stripped of imagery, self-referential abstraction is largely devoid of symbols and disconnected from experience in the surrounding world, cool and low on emotion. Abstraction is predictable in application — polite, inoffensive, and not too meaningful — thereby providing a safe vocabulary for corporate materials. Imagery, on the richly loaded with symbolic, encoded meaning, often ambiguous and other hand, is richly loaded with symbolic, encoded meaning capable of arousing the entire range of human emotions. Imagery is difficult to control, even dangerous or controversial — often leading to unintended personal interpretations on the part of the audience — but also poetic, powerful, and potentially eloquent.

The modernist of agenda has conspired to promote an attitude of apoliticism among American designers, design educators, and students, building on the pragmatic American tendency to avoid political dialectics. American designers consistently take European theories and strip them of their political content. Of the various strains of modernism, many of which were socially concerned or politically revolutionary, American design either chose those most devoid of political content or stripped the theories of their original political idealism.

More recently we have seen a strong interest in French literary theory. But its original element of French contemporary Marxism has been largely ignored in the U.S., perhaps rightly so. The American political environment is far different from the

European; European political dialectics may not be appropriate to us. Yet we cannot assume that no political theory is needed to ground our work — all designers need an appropriate framework to evaluate and assess the impacts of their work with its social/ethical/political milieu. Perhaps this evaluative framework is different for each individual, dependent on the values of each, reflecting strong tradition of American individualism.

Designers must break out of the obedient, neutral servant-to-industry mentality, an orientation that particularly strong in the Reagan-Thatcher-Bush years, and continues to dominate design management and strategic design. Yes, we are problem-solvers responding to the needs of clients. But we must consider the problems we take on. Should one help sell tobacco and alcohol, or design a Presidential memorial library for a man who reads only pulp cowboy novels? Does society really benefit from a strategic plan for plastic housewares or fast-food? The answers may be more subtle than a yes or no. But one thing is clear: Design is not a neutral, value-free process. A design has no more integrity than its purpose or subject matter. Garbage in, garbage out. The most rarefied design solution can never surpass the quality of its content.

A dangerous assumption is that corporate work of innocuous content is devoid of political bias. The vast majority of student design projects deal with corporate needs, placing a heavy priority on the corporate economic sector of our society. Commerce is where we are investing our assets of time, budgets, skills, and creativity. This is a decisive vote for economics over other potential concerns, including social, educational, cultural, spiritual, and political needs. This is a political statement in itself both in education and practice.

Postwar American art has greatly ignored societal issues as well. The self-reference of abstract expressionism and minimalism has been largely divorced from external conditions. Pop art embraced materialism more than it critiqued it. The more recent postmodernist ironic parodies have been full of duplicity and offer no program as antidote to the appalling paradigms they deconstruct. But the past several years have brought a new involvement by artists in the socio-political environment around them. A recent book, *The Reenchantment of Art*, advocates a second post-modernism, a reconstruction that moves beyond the detachment of modernism and deconstruction. Suzi Gablik, the author, calls for an end to the alienation of artists and aesthetics from social values in a new interrelational, audience-oriented art.

There are signs that this is happening. Issue-oriented art has been spreading like wildfire among graduate students in the fine arts. At Cranbrook and a number of other design programs, fine arts students are attending graphic design critiques, eager to learn design methods for reaching their audiences. Fashion advertising is beginning to occasionally embrace issues. Perhaps humanistic content is good for sales: witness Esprit, Benetton, Moschino. That these clients are prepared to make social advocacy part of their message is evidence of a need and receptivity in their audiences. But are many graphic designers prepared to deal with this type

of content? Graphic design is a powerful tool, capable of informing, publicizing, and propagandizing social, environmental, and political messages as well as commercial ones.

How does compassionate design shape a practice? The occasional pro bono piece as a relief from business as usual is not the answer here. The choice of clients or content is crucial. The most fortunate can find a worthy cause in need of a designer with the funds to pay for professional design services. Unfortunately, good causes often seem to have the least resources in our present economic system. Is it possible to shape a practice around non-business clients or introduce social content into commercial work? The compassionate designer must strategize an ethical practice and be an informed, involved citizen in a Jeffersonian participatory democracy, agile and flexible, prepared to turn the tools of visual communications toward a broad spectrum of needs.

How does one educate graphic design students with an understanding of design as a social and political force? Can a political consciousness be trained? Can an educator teach values? The answer is probably no in the simplistic sense. However, the field of education has a well-developed area referred to as “values clarification” that offers many possibilities for graphic design educators. Too often we take individuals with eighteen years of experience and strip them of their values, rather than cultivate them for effective application in design practice.

In teaching, these issues must be raised from the beginning for the design student. This is not something to spring on the advanced student after their attitudes have been fixed on neutrality. At the core of this issue is the content of the projects we assign from the very first introductory exercise. Most introductory graphic design courses are based on abstract formal exercises inherited from the Bauhaus and the classic Basel school projects. The detachment problem begins here. These projects either deal with completely abstract form — point, line, and plane, for instance — or they remove imagery from context. The graphic translation projects, so effective in training a keen formal sense, unfortunately use a process of abstractional analysis, thereby stripping imagery of its encoded symbolism. (I have to admit to being guilty of this in my assignments in past years.) Divorcing design form from content or context is a lesson in passivity, implying that graphic form is something separate and unrelated to subjective values or even ideas. The first principle is that all graphic projects must have content.

The type of content in each assignment is crucial. It is disheartening to see the vast number of undergraduate projects dedicated to selling goods and services in the marketplace devoid of any mission beyond business success. Undoubtedly all students need experience in this type of message and purpose. But cannot projects cover a broad mix of content, including issues beyond business? Cultural, social, and political subjects make excellent communications challenges for student designers.

Project assignments can require content developed by the student dealing with public and personal social, political, and economic issues and current events. The responsibility for developing content is a crucial one; it counteracts the passive design role in which one unquestioningly accepts client-dictated copy. On a practical level, we know how frequently all designers modify and improve client copy-writing; many graphic designers become quite good writers and editors, so closely is our function allied to writing. In a larger sense, however, self-developed content and copy promotes two important attitudes in a design student. One is the ability to develop personal content and subject matter, executed independently of client the assignments, where the reward is the expression of personal concerns. Secondly, the challenge to develop subject matter stimulates the design student to determine what matters on a personal level. A process of values clarification must go on in the student before a subject or subject-matter position can be chosen. And the breadth of concerns chosen as subjects by fellow students exposes each student to a wider range of possibilities.

The critique process for issue-oriented work can be a very effective forum for values clarification. This is particularly true of group critiques in which all students are encouraged to participate, rather than the authoritarian traditionalist crit in which the faculty do all the talking. In evaluating the success or failure of a piece of graphic communications, each critic must address the subject matter and understand the student's stated intentions before weighing a piece's success. This expands the critique discussion beyond the usual and necessary topics of graphic method, form, and technique. Tolerance as well as objectivity are required of each critique participant, in that they must accept and understand the student's intended message before evaluating the piece.

For instance, two fundamentalist Christian students recently brought their religiously oriented work to Cranbrook graphic design crits during a two-semester period. It was a challenge — and a lesson in tolerance — for the other students to put aside their personal religious (or non-religious) conviction in order to give these students and their work a fair critique from a level playing field. It was quite remarkable — and refreshing — to find us all discussing spirituality as legitimate subject matter. This has held true for many other subjects from the universe of issues facing our culture today, including local and global environmental issues, animal rights, homelessness, feminism, and reproductive choice.

The point here is content. As design educators, we cast projects almost as a scientist designs a laboratory experiment. The formula and the variables conspire to slant the results in one direction or another. The project assignment and the project critique are powerful tools that teach far more than explicit goals, and carry strong implicit messages about design and designers' roles.

Design history also offers a rich resource for understanding the relationship of form and content to socio-political contexts. We all know how often works from art and design history are venerated (and imitated) in an atmosphere divorced from their

original context. By exploring the accompanying cultural/social/political histories, students can see the contextual interdependencies and make analogies to their present time.

Am I advocating the production of a generation of designers preoccupied with political activism, a kind of reborn sixties mentality? I think rather what I have in mind is nurturing a crop of active citizens — informed, concerned participants in society who happen to be graphic designers. We must stop inadvertently training our students to ignore their convictions and be passive economic servants. Instead, we must help them to clarify their personal values and to give them the tools to recognize when it is appropriate to act on them. I do think this is possible. We still need objectivity, but this includes the objectivity to know when to invoke personal biases and when to set them aside. Too often our graduates and their work emerge as charming mannequins, voiceless mouthpieces for the messages of ventriloquist clients. Let us instead give designers their voices so they may participate and contribute more fully in the world around them.

Originally presented as a talk at the Design Renaissance International Conference, Glasgow, Scotland, September 4, 1993, and then at the American Institute of Graphic Arts National Conference, Seattle, Washington, September 29, 1995.

Beyond Pro Bono

Graphic Design's Social Work

• Anne Bush

Manifestos are meant to get under our skin. Committed to their biases, brevity, and zeal, they do not rehash established positions but underscore the questionable ones. They invite and expect response. Not surprisingly, it is rarely the manifesto itself, but rather the ensuing dialogue, that is of the most interest, in which ideas are tested and ideologies revealed. The “First Things First Manifesto 2000”¹ is a case in point. Circulated last year on the Web and in the professional design press, this manifesto professed the importance of design that attends to social needs rather than pandering to the prescriptions of capitalist consumption. The response to this was varied. Predictably, some took issue with the oversimplification of issues and with the unspoken agendas that were attached (fair enough, but it is a manifesto after all). Unpredictably, some toyed with the very structure of the manifesto itself by cagily inserting abbreviated commentary into the list of signatures. Akin to graffiti or tagging, these interventions combined banal sarcasm with pointed critique. In so doing, they occupied a conventional space in an unconventional manner and served to underline an incredibly simple, yet often over-looked, point about communication that it is fundamentally about exchange. It is an engagement with a real audience, one that doesn't always fit neatly into original assumptions about interpretation and, in some cases, can reconfigure a message entirely. Moreover, nowhere is such an understanding more important than in discussions about social responsibility itself.

I have always felt a certain unease with the general ways in which the design profession has framed notions of social responsibility. Frequently defined by acts of generosity (i.e., pro bono designs for not-for-profit agencies) or environmentalism (i.e., the use of recycled paper and soy-based inks), the design profession, in many cases, limits social responsibility to acts of benevolence or good will. Recently, this situation has been complicated further by the increasing celebration of design authorship. Although the inclusion of voices should be a welcome of initiative, too frequently the overriding voice is still that of the designer. As a result, both civic benevolence and authorship tend to maintain (in many instances perhaps

inadvertently) the historical notion of the designer as master communicator, the problem-solver. Yet, communication is dialogic. It depends on exchange. Thus, a more accurate understanding of visual communication invokes not only the voices of designers, but the voices of designers in concert with the voices of the audience. It is here, in the virtual space of dialogue, that social “responsibility” takes on the full complexity of its meaning and that the challenge for graphic design unfolds.

Most designers, I believe, would agree that design has an important social role, and that design practice should be anchored in the very reality of its social consequences. To understand these consequences, however, is to understand how messages function — they are completed by readers who bring their own expectations and interpretive practices to the exchange. This is a scary proposition for many designers. As long as the design profession continues to celebrate the designer-as-author, it continues to hold onto the means of production. It maintains a sense of control, and in a discipline whose professional identity is increasingly threatened by the democratizing effects of new technology, control is security. Yet such security is an illusion. Instances of miscommunication continually remind us that visual communication is a collaborative process. More important, it is this dialogic process that defines visual communication as a social activity. To teach social responsibility, then is in part to foster an understanding of visual communication as exchange and then to understand that such exchanges are never entirely predictable or neat.

In a graduate seminar that I facilitate at the Universidad de las Américas (UDLA) in Cholula, Mexico, students study the relationship between designing and reading practices as different, yet connected, forms of making meaning. In the course, students are asked to select an example of visual communication and then examine the similarities and differences between the intended meaning and the eventual response to the message. Questions they are asked to consider include: what meanings are shared and by what groups; what intended meanings are contested and what counter-meanings are constructed and circulated; how is the visual and verbal language that is employed constitutive or reflective of certain groups and positions; and how does the struggle for meaning reflect or resist institutional power structures. The ultimate goal for students is to recognize that meaning is always the result of a range of cultural and social negotiations and the designer is not the sole determinant, but rather a participant, in these dialogues.

In her analysis of a poster campaign developed by the Mexican government, Erica Wong examined the discrepancy between an institutionally designed message and its community reception.² The goal of the governmental campaign was to provide information about health and nutrition to rural indigenous communities. The posters, which featured a single image of a smiling boy in traditional dress, were produced in black and white and were posted in the local health clinics as well as on trees and lampposts in the rural towns. Unfortunately, despite the best of intentions, both the government and the designer underestimated the ways in which the posters would ultimately be read by the local population. Wong points out

that the design of the poster, which uses a grainy black-and-white image, fails in very fundamental ways to communicate to its audience. First, by referencing the documentary fine art traditions, epitomized in the images of Mexico by Alvarez Bravo and Tina Modotti, the photography attempts to capture indigenous culture as a kind of romantic and static essence. It becomes a kind of visual anthropology that says more about the conceptions of its makers than the reality of its intended audience. More disturbingly, Wong discovered through interviews with the local communities that many people misunderstood the intention entirely. For citizens bound by a strong sense of community and family, the boy in the image appeared abandoned. The people of the villages couldn't understand why he had been left alone. They also couldn't reconcile this sense of isolation with the posed quality of the photograph. If he was alone, why was he smiling for the camera? The synthetic, portrait-like framing combined with the celebratory dress (normally saved for special occasions) further confused the reading. Many said that they initially overlooked the poster, because they thought it was an advertisement for tourism, since similar portrait images of traditional culture (usually in black and white) were a common visual theme in the marketing of Mexican heritage. Wong reminds us, however, that although depicting indigenous culture in black and white is a common representational practice, it reinforces nostalgic ways of seeing and continues to locate indigenous culture in a perpetual past. Moreover, it differs greatly from the sense of color and activity that is a part of everyday reality in rural Mexican communities. For the local population, then, the poster not only mirrored the imagery of travel and promotion, but, unfortunately, also served to reinforce regional fears of governmental encroachment and the dissolution of traditional ways of life.

In another example from the same course, Manuel Parga analyzes a poster campaign for the New Liberal Party in Colombia and points out how a message of economic opportunity, extended to the working classes in the 1989 presidential campaign, actually raises more questions than it answers. For the New Liberal Party, progress translates as technological development, economic diversification and growth, and the elimination of premodern bad habits (i.e., political and economic corruption, informal business alliances, etc.). Thus, modernization, as Parga explains, was understood by the New Liberals as advancement, as an important step toward being a participant in the global economy. Yet Parga goes on to explain that because modernization in Colombia, as in other parts of Latin America, was aligned initially with colonization, it tended to support the privileged rather than the working classes. Instead of working to secure more opportunity for the average citizen, modernization, in many ways, has solidified social and cultural distinctions. As a result, Parga explains, many of the lower and middle classes are suspicious of modernization rhetoric, as, all too frequently, they see governmental invocations of progress and working-class solidarity as a facade sanctioned by the upper classes to keep social divisions in place.

Parga explains the intentions of the Liberal Party by analyzing the reading of the visual symbols (ie., Colombian flag, the juxtaposed images of candidates past and

present, the arms of the candidate raised in a V shape, and the typography). What is more interesting in the campaign, however, is the manner in which classic images of working-class empowerment (rolled shirt sleeves, the raised arms of victorious defiance against an image of a flag, for example) are problematic because of the specific social and cultural context in which they are circulated. Industrialization in Latin America, while creating jobs and energizing economies, has had both positive and negative consequences. Imported primarily by European colonizers, the celebration of industrialization meant that the tenets of European modernism were mapped onto a reality that was far from homogeneous. Yet, according to Parga, Latin America is better understood “as a more complex articulation of traditions, as well as diverse and unequal modernities, a heterogeneous continent formed by countries where, in each one, multiple logics of development coexist.”³ Such a diverse landscape necessarily contains multiple audiences as well. Thus, ultimately, by packaging the notion of progress as an overall call to the fictional working masses the New Liberal in Party, in many ways, reinforced the rhetoric of existing power structures rather than interacting with a more conflicted social reality. It attempted to represent rather than engage potential readers. Parga concludes his analysis by calling for more inclusive communication agendas — ones that respect and address the diversity and traditions of their readers.

What these examples underline is the fact that messages never occupy an objective position in relationship to meaning. They are always completed by readers/ viewers anchored in very specific contexts. Moreover, these interpretations often differ from a message's (or action's) intended meanings, since every response is a contingent one (personally and collectively). Not only do readers approach texts from differing degrees of literacy, but readers who do share a common reading ability do not always read messages in the same manner.⁴ Consider, for example, the ways in which different audiences respond to different typographic or image choices and their combination. Media only complicates this further. Computers and the myriad of complimentary hand-held electronic devices have changed forever conventional ideas about reading practices. They also demonstrate how individual communities, in turn, possess their own modes of legitimizing particular communication media and methods of interpretation. Ultimately communication is a dynamic process that inserts certain preferred meanings into sites where they are accepted, rejected, or reinterpreted. To understand the dynamic of this exchange is to have what C. W. Mills refers to as the sociological imagination, to understand one position and how it is conditioned by the world in which it is developed and voiced (professionally, intellectually, and socially).

Such understanding is also, in the end, linked to culture since social actions cannot be understood outside cultural contexts. Understandings actually construct our social worlds: Culture creates a world that makes sense. “In order to conduct a social practice, we need to give it a certain meaning, have a conception of it, be able to think meaningfully about it. The production of social meanings is, therefore, a necessary precondition for the functioning of a social practice and an account of the cultural conditions of social practices must form part of the sociological explanation

of how they work. Cultural description and analysis is, therefore, increasingly crucial to the production of sociological knowledge.”⁵ We accept that part of the way in which we know the world is through representations, the contexts in which they circulate, and how such languages are read, used, and subverted. It is here, in my opinion, that the academy performs its most significant role, since fostering the ability to analyze and question encourages debate and action.

A potential theoretical model for such analysis lies in Michel de Certeau’s discussion of the distinction between strategies and tactics.” According to de Certeau, strategies constitute the official languages of a discipline. Promoted through education and disciplinary assimilation, they circumscribe the accepted views of a group. In graphic design these views translate into the preferred visual languages of the profession (the result of the marriage of American advertising and European modernist aesthetics). In the discipline of graphic design, our strategies frequently conceal the power relations that sustain them, and separate us from the potentially productive, resistant, and contestatory interpretations of actual users. They reinforce existing notions of graphic design from the safe distance of conference rooms and classrooms rather than investigate the full dimensions (including successes and failures) of a communicative act. For designers to understand the social dimensions of professionally sanctioned languages, they have to study the tactics of actual users. Like reading itself, a tactic is a seized opportunity. It does not rest in a consistent and comfortable place, but acts in real time. It turns ways of reading into ways of speaking — passive readers into active readers who have a definite say in the message. Reading, then, embodies its own rhetorical constructions and these underline the need to study the total communicative act as one that empowers speakers on both sides of a message. For design education, such a reception theory of design means studying the actions and interpretations of audiences as well as those of designers, and potentially finding ways in which both sites of making become more consciously integrated. This study would inform (and probably alter) many conceptions of socially responsible design, as it would reveal how the profession of graphic design, as a discipline occupied with its own official strategies, works in many cases to suppress rather than enable the interpretations of individual users. Although, one could argue that such interpretations cannot be anticipated, it would be interesting to explore ways in which an active dialogue between the designer, and audience could result in more collaborative (and ultimately productive) communications that are interactive in their actual intent and that function through joint design rather than prescribed condition. In the best sense, such visual messages would work to encourage self-cultivating publics⁷ rather than mass conformity. In the design classroom, this begins with encouraging critical and self-aware citizens.

It has been said that the role of professional education is to make the framework of a discipline explicit. Yet such defining should be done not to curtail discussion but to encourage it. As C. W. Mills points out, definitions invite others to see the world in a particular way. And, in so doing, they change the discussion from an argument over terms into a disagreement about fact, and thus open arguments to further inquiry.⁸

This expanded inquiry finds fertile ground in the classroom, since this is the place where debate is unbounded by commercial and economic restrictions. It is the place where one practices the art of thinking out loud but intelligibly — where all viewpoints can be explored, and assumptions, methods, and judgments can be laid bare.⁹ This is not to say that classroom discussions should dissolve into subjective relativity, but that they should maintain a sense of free exchange, even when positions champion less-popular views. If graphic design education is, in large part a study of the preferred definitions of the profession, it is also, in its best sense, a site for contests and reinterpretations — a site for students and teachers to pose critical and thoughtful questions about professional ideologies and ultimately their own.

In the most fundamental sense, then, responsibility is the ability to respond, not just the willingness to act, but also the ability to understand one’s actions, the context in which they are applied, and the widest range of implications for their reception and potential reinterpretation. To teach this ability is to teach a critical awareness of the entire communicative act, not just an awareness of one’s personal contribution. When we teach critical understanding, when we investigate our own positions (what we take as fact, the methods that we invoke, and the judgments that we make) as well as the contexts of specific social situations, we encourage accountability. In my opinion, this is the role of the academy. What design education can contribute to participatory society is the engaged and aware citizen who understands the ramifications of action and inaction, yet (ultimately) is given the option to choose.

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Notes

1. The “First Things First Manifesto 2000” is a new version of the original “First Things First Manifesto” written thirty-seven years ago by Ken Garland. It was published with thirty-three signatories’ names in Adbusters, Emigre, the AIGA Journal, Eye, Blueprint, Items, and Form. A copy of the “First Things First Manifesto 2000” is currently posted (along with the original version and readers’ responses) on the Adbusters Web site: www.adbusters.org.
2. Erica Wong, “Designing the Marginal: Mexican Assumptions in Representation” (unpublished essay).
3. Manuel Parga, “Beyond Instrumental Power: A Critical Analysis of Cesar Gaviria Trujillos Political Campaign” (unpublished essay), 6.
4. Roger Chartier, *The Order of Books* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1994), 4. Chartier makes an important correction here when he points out that the essential but oversimplified separation of the literate from the illiterate does not exhaust the full range of differences in readers’ relationships to writing
5. Paul du Gay, Stuart Hall, Linda Janes, Hugh Mackay, and Keith Negus, *Doing Cultural Studies: The story of the Sony Walkman* (London: Sage Publications, 1997), 2.
6. Michel de Certeau, *The Practice of Everyday Life* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1988), xix.
7. C. Wright Mills, *The Sociological Imagination* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000), 186–187.
8. *Ibid.*, 34.
9. *Ibid.*, 79.

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